

Film Archiver

A desktop application for building a structured, searchable film photography archive. Film Archiver bridges your digital scans with physical negative storage through a thoughtful naming system and rich metadata embedding.

The Archive Philosophy

Film Archiver creates a **dual-layer organization system** designed to work independently yet complement each other:

Layer 1: Finder-Based Archive

Your film scans live in a structured folder hierarchy that you control—completely independent from any photo management software. This gives you:

- Direct access via Finder/file browser
- Easy backup and portability
- Quick visual navigation by year/roll
- No lock-in to any specific application

Layer 2: Metadata Integration

EXIF metadata embedded in each file enables seamless integration with photo management apps (Lightroom, Capture One, Photo Mechanic, etc.):

- **Date metadata** keeps files chronologically organized in catalogs
- **Lens metadata** enables filtering and searching by lens
- Import into any DAM software and maintain organization automatically

Recommended Practice: Store your Film Archive folder separately from where your photo management app stores its managed files. This keeps your master archive navigable in Finder while still accessible to catalog software.

Recommended Folder Structure

Set up a master archive folder with subfolders organized by year:

```
Film Archive/
├── 2023/
│   ├── 001-CLE-400D-JAN23/
│   │   ├── 001-01-CLE-400D.jpg
│   │   ├── 001-02-CLE-400D.jpg
│   │   └── ...
│   ├── 002-CLE-HP5-FEB23/
│   └── ...
├── 2024/
│   ├── 045-AE1P-PORTRA400-MAR24/
│   └── ...
└── 2025/
    └── ...
```

Opening any year folder shows every roll shot that year in chronological order, easily searchable by roll number, camera, or film stock.

The Naming Format

Folder Naming

```
{ROLL}-{CAMERA}-{STOCK}-{MONTH}{YR}
```

Component	Purpose	Example
ROLL	Unique archive catalog number	001 , 045 , 1000
CAMERA	Camera body used	CLE , AE1P , M6
STOCK	Film stock	400D , HP5 , PORTRA400
MONTH+YR	When the roll was shot	JAN23 , MAR24 , NOV25

Example: 023-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400-NOV25

File Naming

```
{ROLL}-{FRAME}-{CAMERA}-{STOCK}.ext
```

Component	Purpose	Example
ROLL	Same catalog number as folder	023
FRAME	Frame number within roll	01 , 15 , 36
CAMERA	Camera body (redundant for safety)	CANON_AE1P
STOCK	Film stock (redundant for safety)	PORTRA400

Example: 023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400.jpg

Optional Suffixes

For push/pull processing or shooting at a different ISO:

Situation	Suffix	Example Filename
Pushed +1	(+1)	023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400(+1).jpg
Pulled -1	(-1)	023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400(-1).jpg
Shot at ISO 800	(@800)	023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400(@800).jpg

Why Duplicate Names Are Impossible

The naming scheme is designed so that **every file has a globally unique name**, even if files accidentally get moved to wrong folders:

1. **Roll number is unique** across your entire archive (you never reuse a roll number)
2. **Frame number is unique** within each roll (01-36 typically)
3. The combination of `ROLL-FRAME` creates a unique identifier that can never collide

Even if you moved `023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400.jpg` into the folder for roll 045, the filename itself contains roll 023 so there's no ambiguity about which negative it came from.

Dynamic Roll Numbering

Film Archiver automatically adjusts padding based on your archive size:

Archive Size	Padding	Examples
Rolls 1-999	3 digits	001 , 023 , 999
Rolls 1000+	4+ digits	1000 , 1234 , 5432

This ensures proper alphabetical sorting regardless of how large your archive grows.

Metadata Benefits

EXIF Date Embedding

Film Archiver sets these date fields in each file:

- `DateTimeOriginal` — when the photo was taken
- `DateTimeDigitized` — synced to the same date
- `DateTime` — file modification date
- macOS creation date (on Mac)

Result: Import files into any photo management app and they automatically sort chronologically, regardless of when they were scanned.

Lens Metadata

Store the lens used for each frame in the EXIF `LensModel1` field:

- Filter photos by lens in your catalog software
- Track which lenses you use most
- Apply different lenses to individual frames within a roll

Cross-Referencing Physical ↔ Digital

The roll number is your **universal catalog ID** linking digital files to physical negatives.

Finding the Negative for a Digital File

1. Note the roll number from the filename (e.g., `023-15-...` → Roll 023)
2. Find physical negative sleeve labeled `023`
3. Locate frame 15 on the sleeve

Finding Digital Files for a Physical Negative

1. Note the roll number on the sleeve (e.g., `023`)
2. In Finder: search for `023-` in your Film Archive
3. In your photo app: filter by filename containing `023-`

Features

- **Image preview** with thumbnail caching
- **Favorites** for cameras, films, and lenses
- **Per-file lens assignment** for rolls shot with multiple lenses
- **Reverse file order** toggle (labs often scan in reverse)
- **Date picker** with calendar widget
- **Push/Pull notation** or custom shot-at ISO
- **Dark mode** support (follows macOS system setting)
- **RAW format support** (CR2, CR3, NEF, ARW, DNG, etc.)

Getting Started

See the detailed [Installation & Usage Guide](#) in the app directory.

Quick Start:

1. Download the latest `.dmg` from [Releases](#)
2. Drag Film Archiver to Applications
3. Add your scanned files
4. Fill in roll number, camera, film, and date
5. Click **Process Files** and choose your output folder

Version

Current version: 1.2.2

See [Changelog](#) for release history.

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